DAILY READING • 样张

Nine Hundred Seats

2026-11-11 · 当天 50 词全部覆盖 · 全文 608 词 · 5 段

短文

By noon the heat over Millers Field had begun to accelerate, and the cement of the lower stands held it like a stove lid. Iris came through the gate at eleven, past the bulletin board where the lineup had been pinned crooked and the environmental club's bins stood unemptied, then found the equipment room in its usual mess. Cups were plentiful in the storeroom but ice was not, and the shortage had already reached the press box. She sat upright on her stool, rubbed the game balls with river mud until each one lost its shine, and read the wind: moderate, out of the southwest, enough to push a fly ball twelve feet.

Below her the walk-up music started, written by a composer who had never watched a baseball game. There was a mystery on the third row as well: an old woman in a green hat. Iris had learned to associate that hat with the seventh inning, when she rose and left without a word. At twenty-four she was three credits from a physics degree, and she cherished these hours, when relativity stopped being an equation and became something a person could feel. One name on the roster belonged to a man in exile from the majors, sent down in June and still refusing to speak. A research fellowship offer lay unopened in her bag, and the puddles in the aisle reflected the light standards like small imaginary moons.

The visitors' pitcher was dominant from the first pitch, and by the third inning his fastball had invaded every plan the Millers had made. The sensitivity of the radar gun in the press box caught each fluctuation, and the reading climbed past ninety-four. What troubled Iris was his arm, rebuilt by a ligament transplant in nineteen months, faster than any surgeon had promised. The burden of a two-strike count fell on every batter in the order, and their resistance lasted exactly one inning. In the ramp seats a boy with a handicap called each pitch before it left the hand. Then the home starter lost his stability, walked two men, and the score exploded; the stands could accommodate nine hundred, and most of them were standing.

By five the clouds had come over the light standards, and the league authority had a decision to make. A city council candidate was working the aisles, shaking hands and lobbying for the

ballpark's repair budget, while an environmental advocate beside him argued that the old stands should come down entirely. The convention in that league was simple: after five innings the game belonged to the weather. Iris outlined three options on the back of her score sheet, and the two clubs agreed to undertake a hurried negotiation under the stands. The argument stayed civil, which surprised her, and the compromise they reached was to cancel the second game.

The rain came at six and stopped at seven, and a troop of scouts in the upper deck began to sing. Someone passed a bucket for the donation that would pay for new lights, and by nine the total had reached one hundred and forty dollars. Three summers of exposure had taught Iris that a two-run lead meant nothing here, and she wrote her finding in the margin. On the wall by the gate hung a small plaque, where the first racial barrier in the league had been broken. A boy imitated the visitors' closer in the parking lot, slapping his glove, and she negotiated a lift home with the groundskeeper, thinking about the tuition the fellowship would cover and the ambitious plan she had carried since spring.

解析 · 行间留白，可直接手写

By noon the heat over Millers Field **had begun to accelerate**, and the cement of the lower stands held it like a stove lid. Iris came through the gate at eleven, past the bulletin board where the lineup had been pinned crooked and the environmental club's bins stood unemptied, then found the equipment room **in its usual mess**. Cups were plentiful in the storeroom but ice was not, and the shortage had already reached the press box. She sat upright on her stool, rubbed the game balls with river mud until each one lost its shine, and read the wind: moderate, **out of the southwest**, enough to push a fly ball twelve feet.

> **had begun to accelerate** 开始加剧 begin to do 后接动词原形；accelerate 除了“加速”，也常形容抽象事物的势头，如 heat / growth / decline。
> **in its usual mess** 照旧一片凌乱 in a mess 表状态，可插入 usual / terrible 等修饰；mess 作名词是“脏乱”，作动词才是“弄乱”。
> **out of the southwest** 来自西南方向 说风向用 out of 或 from + 方位；这里省略了 coming，与 moderate 并列描述风。

Below her the walk-up music started, written by a composer who had never watched a baseball game. There was a mystery on the third row as well: an old woman in a green hat. Iris had **learned to associate** that hat with the seventh inning, when she rose and left without a word. At twenty-four she was three credits from a physics degree, and she cherished these hours, when relativity stopped being an equation and became something a person could feel. One name on the roster belonged to a man **in exile from the majors**, sent down in June and still refusing to speak. **A research fellowship** offer lay unopened in her bag, and the puddles in the aisle reflected the light standards like small imaginary moons.

> **learned to associate** 学会了把……联系起来 associate A with B 是固定搭配，介词只能用 with；名词 association 后面同样接 with。
> **in exile from the majors** 被逐出大联盟的处境 in exile 表状态，from 引出被逐出的地方或组织；作动词时用 exile sb from sth。
> **A research fellowship** 一项研究奖学金 fellowship 多指带研究或进修任务的资助，强调“职位＋津贴”，比 scholarship 更正式，常与 research / teaching 连用。

The visitors' pitcher was **dominant from the first pitch**, and by the third inning his fastball had invaded every plan the Millers had made. The sensitivity of the radar gun in the press box caught each fluctuation, and the reading climbed past ninety-four. What troubled Iris was his arm, rebuilt by **a ligament transplant** in nineteen months, faster than any surgeon had promised. **The burden of a two-strike count** fell on every batter in the order, and their resistance lasted exactly one inning. In the ramp seats a boy with a handicap called each pitch before it left the hand. Then the home starter lost his stability, walked two men, and the score exploded; the stands could accommodate nine hundred, and most of them were standing.

> **dominant from the first pitch** 从第一球起就压制对手 dominant 后接 from / throughout + 时间点，说明压制从何时开始或贯穿全程；比 strong 更强调压倒对方。
> **a ligament transplant** 韧带移植 transplant 作名词可直接修饰器官或组织（heart / ligament transplant）；“给某人移植”用 transplant on sb。
> **The burden of a two-strike count** 两好球计数带来的压力 burden of + 名词 表“……的负担”，动词搭配 bear / carry / ease，不说 do a burden。

By five the clouds had come over the light standards, and the league authority had a decision to make. A city council candidate was **working the aisles**, shaking hands and **lobbying for** the ballpark's repair budget, while an environmental advocate beside him argued that the old stands should come down entirely. The convention in that league was simple: after five innings the game belonged to the weather. Iris outlined three options on the back of her score sheet, and the two clubs agreed to undertake a hurried negotiation under the stands. The argument **stayed civil**, which surprised her, and the compromise they reached was to cancel the second game.

> **working the aisles** 在过道间挨个走动（拉票、打招呼） work the room / the aisles 指在人群中逐个接触，此处 work 不是“工作”，而是“经营、周旋”。
> **lobbying for** 为……游说 lobby for / against + 名词；lobby sb to do sth 表游说某人做某事，说客是 lobbyist。
> **stayed civil** 始终保持客气 stay + 形容词 表状态延续，相当于 remain；civil 侧重“不失礼、没撕破脸”，比 polite 更强调克制。

The rain came at six and stopped at seven, and **a troop of scouts** in the upper deck began to sing. Someone passed a bucket for the donation that would pay for new lights, and by nine the total had reached one hundred and forty dollars. Three summers of exposure had taught Iris that a two-run lead meant nothing here, and she **wrote her finding** in the margin. On the wall by the gate hung a small plaque, where the first racial barrier in the league had been broken. A boy imitated the visitors' closer in the parking lot, slapping his glove, and she **negotiated a lift home** with the groundskeeper, thinking about the tuition the fellowship would cover and the ambitious plan she had carried since spring.

> **a troop of scouts** 一队童子军 troop 作量词用于成群的人或动物，后接复数名词；troops（恒用复数）则多指军队。
> **wrote her finding** 写下她的结论 finding 指调查或研究得出的结果，正式文体多用复数 findings，常与 publish / report / confirm 连用。
> **negotiated a lift home** 谈妥搭车回家 negotiate 可直接接“谈成的东西”（a deal / a fare / a lift），不必加 about；与某人谈某事用 negotiate with sb for sth。

正午时，米勒球场上方的热浪开始加剧，下层看台的水泥把热气兜住，像一块烧热的炉盖。艾里斯十一点从大门进来，经过公告板——出场名单钉得歪歪扭扭，环保社团的回收桶也没人清空——随后发现器材室照旧一片凌乱。储藏室里纸杯充足，冰却不够，短缺已经传到了记者席。她端坐在高凳上，用河泥把比赛用球一只只搓到失去光泽，然后读风：中等风力，来自西南，足够把高飞球多推出十二英尺。

她下方响起了球员上场音乐，作曲的人从没看过一场棒球赛。第三排也藏着一个谜：一位戴绿帽子的老太太。艾里斯已经学会把那顶帽子与第七局联系起来——那时她总会起身，一言不发地离开。二十四岁的她离物理学学位只差三个学分，她珍爱这些时辰：相对论在这里不再是一个方程，而成了人能感觉到的东西。名单上有一个名字属于一位被放逐出大联盟的人，六月被下放，至今拒绝开口。一封研究奖学金的录取信还没拆，躺在她的包里；过道里的积水把灯塔映成几个小小的、虚构的月亮。

客队投手从第一球起就占据压倒性优势，到第三局，他的快球已经打乱了米勒队所有的计划。记者席上测速枪的灵敏度捕捉到每一次波动，读数爬过了九十四英里。让艾里斯不安的是他的手臂：韧带移植之后十九个月就回来了，比任何外科医生承诺的都快。两好球计数的压力落在每一位打者身上，他们的抵抗只维持了一局。斜坡座位上，一个身有残疾的男孩在球离手之前就喊出了球种。随后主队先发投手失去了稳定性，连投两次保送，比分一下子炸开；看台能容纳九百人，而此刻大多数人都站着。

五点，云已经压过灯塔，联盟当局必须做出决定。一位市议员候选人正在过道间穿梭，握手、为球场维修预算游说；身旁一位环保拥护者则主张这些旧看台应当整体拆掉。那个联盟的惯例很简单：五局之后，比赛归天气管。艾里斯在记分表背面列出了三个方案，两家俱乐部在看台下匆匆进行了一次协商。争论始终没有失礼，这让她意外；他们达成的折中方案是：取消第二场。

雨六点来，七点停；上层看台一队童子军开始唱歌。有人传了个桶，为装新灯募捐，到九点总额到了一百四十美元。三个夏天的接触让艾里斯明白，在这里两分领先什么也不算，于是她把结论写在了页边。大门边的墙上挂着一块小牌子，上面记着这个联盟第一次被打破的种族壁垒。停车场里，一个男孩模仿客队终结者的动作，拍着手套；她跟场地管理员谈妥了搭车回家，一边想着那笔奖学金能付的学费，和从春天起就揣着的那个野心不小的计划。